Deforestation is the removal of forest or woodland for conversion to nonforest use. This can be conversion to agricultural land, including cattle ranches, or development for housing, industry, or transportation. Forest may be degraded without being destroyed completely, when valuable mature trees, such as teak, are selectively logged or some trees are cut down to create a road. This can have a disproportionate negative effect on the biodiversity of the forest, even though most trees are left standing. Another form of deforestation is the clearance of primary forest and its replacement with monoculture plantations, such as palm oil, as has happened extensively in Indonesia.

Deforestation can impact all kinds of forest habitat, but tropical rainforest —tropical moist broadleaf forest that grows between the Tropic of Cancer and the Tropic of Capricorn—is currently the most severely affected. Concern for the rainforest was first raised in the 1970s when activist Chico Mendes—who went on to become a founding member of Brazil's National Council of Rubber Tappers—called on the Brazilian government to establish forest reserves, from which local people could extract natural products, such as nuts, fruits, and fibers, sustainably. Mendes's campaign, which eventually cost him his life, highlighted the ecological damage wreaked by forest clearance.